
28-Day Plant Stabilization Schedule

Purpose: Canonical survival and establishment guidance for the first 28 days after planting¹. This document is agent-readable and conservative by design².

I. Global Guardrails (Always Enforced - P1)

- **Workability:** Plant only when soil is workable; do not plant in frozen or waterlogged soil³.
- **Moisture-Driven:** All watering decisions must be based on actual root-zone moisture; calendar dates are advisory only⁴.
- **Fertilizer Safety:** Avoid quick-release fertilizer at planting or during heat, drought, or dormancy⁵.
- **Preventing Burn:** Never apply fertilizer to dry soil; always water the plant first⁶⁶⁶⁶⁶⁶⁶⁶⁶⁶.
- **Drainage Check:** Pause irrigation after heavy rain; standing water beyond 24 hours indicates a drainage failure⁷.
- **Container Care:** Never allow containers to sit in standing water/saucers⁸.
- **Conflict Resolution:** If advice conflicts, survival rules (\$P1\$) always override optimization guidance⁹.

II. Language & Season Sensitivity (Global - P1)

- **Winter Dormancy:** For deciduous plants in winter, use "dormant establishment" rather than "active growth"¹⁰.
- **Evergreen Monitoring:** Evergreens in winter require moisture monitoring during dry spells even if they appear static¹¹.
- **Warm-Season Thresholds:** Warm-season crops (tomatoes, peppers, basil) must not be planted or described as "ready to grow" until soil temperatures reach $\geq 60^{\circ}\text{F}$ ($\geq 16^{\circ}\text{C}$)¹²¹²¹²¹².

III. Day 0: Planting Day (P1)

- **Correct Depth:** Plant at the same depth as the container; ensure the root flare or crown is at the soil surface¹³¹³¹³¹³¹³¹³¹³¹³.
- **Root Protection:** Never bury the crown of a perennial or the trunk/stem base of a shrub¹⁴¹⁴¹⁴¹⁴.
- **Soil Contact:** Eliminate air pockets by firming soil around the roots¹⁵¹⁵¹⁵¹⁵.
- **Initial Saturation:** Water in thoroughly until the root ball and surrounding soil are fully saturated¹⁶¹⁶¹⁶¹⁶.
- **Mulching Technique:** Apply mulch 2-3 inches deep, but keep it 2-3 inches away from stems and crowns to prevent rot¹⁷¹⁷¹⁷¹⁷¹⁷¹⁷¹⁷¹⁷.

IV. Days 1-7: Acute Establishment (P1)

- **Daily Checks:** Inspect soil moisture daily; water deeply whenever the root zone begins to dry¹⁸.
- **Watering Technique:** Water at the base only; avoid routine overhead watering or wetting foliage late in the day to reduce disease¹⁹¹⁹¹⁹¹⁹¹⁹¹⁹¹⁹¹⁹.
- **Stress Protection:** Provide temporary shade or wind protection if plants wilt during extreme heat or drying winds²⁰²⁰²⁰²⁰.
- **Minimal Intervention:** Do not prune except for dead or broken tissue; avoid "shaping" immediately after planting²¹²¹²¹²¹.

V. Days 8-28: Stabilization & Transition (P1/P2)

- **Days 8-14:** Allow slight surface drying between waterings; recognize that lack of visible growth is normal during dormancy²².
- **Days 15-21:** Gradually extend the time between waterings as soil moisture stabilizes²³.
- **Days 22-28:** Shift from daily checks to weather-responsive monitoring²⁴.
- **Fertilization:** Only consider light, dilute feeding if the plant is in an active growth period and conditions are mild²⁵²⁵²⁵²⁵.

VI. Failure Signals vs. Normal Adjustment (P1)

- **Normal:** Temporary wilt immediately after planting that recovers after watering²⁶²⁶²⁶²⁶.
- **Warning:** Persistent wilt even when soil is wet, stem collapse, or progressive browning/blackening of tissue²⁷²⁷²⁷²⁷.
- **Response:** Treat wet-soil wilt as a drainage problem, not a watering deficit²⁸²⁸²⁸²⁸.